

THE JUNGLE COMMONS

A Three-Act Play

Julian

JUDGE HORNBILL, an elderly hornbill who enjoys procedure almost as much as fruit.

AGRA, matriarch of a leafcutter-ant colony and guardian of its fungus gardens.

NINO, a flamboyant weaver bird and obsessive nest-builder.

SPINNER, an orb-weaver spider, dry, exact, and perpetually repairing something.

PROFESSOR FINN, a cichlid who treats every puddle like a university department.

SKYSHOT, an arowana with excellent aim and a slightly inflated opinion of it.

DAME DAMSEL, a beaver engineer who thinks in gradients, leaks, and timber.

BURR, a burrowing rodent who considers tunnels the highest form of civilization.

MARA, a mycorrhizal fungus speaking through mushrooms and roots.

TIK, a termite architect.

PIP, a tree frog.

RIVER, the voice of moving water.

BAOBAB, an old tree.

PARROT, unofficial journalist of the jungle.

ENSEMBLE, insects, fish, birds, mammals, fungi, plants, and whoever else can fit onstage.

1 EXT. GREAT CLEARING - MORNING

1

A gigantic tree rises at center stage. Roots make natural benches.

A stream curls around one side of the playing space.

PARROT hops onto a branch carrying a rolled leaf.

PARROT

Breaking news! Emergency! Scandal!
Possibly snacks!

JUDGE HORNBILL

Parrot.

PARROT

Yes, Your Beakship?

JUDGE HORNBILL

Just read the notice.

PARROT

Right.

(reading)

"All residents are summoned to determine who owns the jungle's ideas."

The clearing erupts.

NINO

Finally.

SPINNER

This will end badly.

BURR

Can I own silence?

PARROT

You'd have to demonstrate prior use.

BURR

I've been underground for six years.

JUDGE HORNBILL bangs a seedpod.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Order. We have received seventeen complaints, nine counterclaims, three threats involving stinging, and one application to copyright the sunrise.

BAOBAB

That was Parrot.

PARROT

I withdrew it.

AGRA marches in with a column of ants carrying leaf fragments.

AGRA

My colony files first.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Claim?

AGRA

Fungus farming.

MARA

Excuse me?

AGRA

Not fungus. Fungus farming.

She indicates the ants.

AGRA (CONT'D)

We cut leaves, clean them, carry
them
underground, prepare the substrate
and
grow the fungus that feeds our
colony.

PARROT

So you invented agriculture?

AGRA

We didn't say that.

PARROT

You strongly implied it.

AGRA

We invented our agriculture.

NINO swoops down carrying a grass strand.

NINO

Fine. Then I claim weaving.

He ties a dazzling knot.

NINO (CONT'D)

Observe.

Everyone leans closer.

NINO immediately covers the knot with his wing.

NINO (CONT'D)

Not that closely.

SPINNER descends on silk.

SPINNER

If we're doing this, I claim
tensioned
fiber architecture.

NINO

That's weaving.

SPINNER

It's a web.

NINO

String arranged in space.

SPINNER

Your nest is a bag with ambition.

NINO

Take that back.

SPINNER

No.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Excellent. We're six minutes in and already insulting architecture.

A SPLASH.

SKYSHOT rises from the stream.

SKYSHOT

I claim ballistic entomology.

PIP

You mean jumping at bugs?

SKYSHOT

I mean launching from water with enough precision to grab prey above the surface.

PIP

So, jumping at bugs.

SKYSHOT

With geometry.

PROFESSOR FINN surfaces.

PROFESSOR FINN

I claim aquatic parental innovation.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Meaning?

PROFESSOR FINN

Nest defense, brood care, mouthbrooding, depending on the cichlid. We have range.

PARROT

Can you copyright parenting?

PROFESSOR FINN

Parents have tried.

DAME DAMSEL enters dragging a branch twice her size.

DAME DAMSEL

Move.

Everyone moves.

She drops it.

DAME DAMSEL (CONT'D)

Water engineering.

RIVER

I object already.

DAME DAMSEL

Dams slow flow, create ponds, change habitat, hold sediment--

RIVER

Yes. I noticed.

BURR pops from a hole.

BURR

Tunnel engineering.

TIK, the termite, appears beside him.

TIK

Excuse me?

BURR

Here we go.

TIK

Ventilation. Temperature regulation. Load-bearing chambers. We've been doing subterranean architecture forever.

BURR

Your walls taste terrible.

TIK

They're not lunch.

BURR

Everything underground is potentially lunch.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Enough.

He surveys them.

JUDGE HORNBILL (CONT'D)

Each claimant will explain what
makes
their knowledge theirs.

AGRA

Easy. We learned it.

NINO

We perfected it.

SPINNER

We embody it.

DAME DAMSEL

We work for it.

SKYSHOT

We're awesome at it.

PROFESSOR FINN

Ignore him.

JUDGE HORNBILL

And what happens when another
creature
copies you?

A beat.

NINO

They owe me.

AGRA

They stop.

SPINNER

Depends whether the copying is
competent.

BURR

I hide deeper.

DAME DAMSEL

I send an invoice.

RIVER

To whom?

DAME DAMSEL

Still designing that part.

MARA

Interesting.

Everyone turns toward a cluster of mushrooms.

MARA (CONT'D)

You all speak as though knowledge
grew
inside sealed jars.

AGRA

Our fungus grows inside chambers.

MARA

Not the same thing.

MARA's underground threads glow faintly across the stage.

MARA (CONT'D)

But continue.

I enjoy watching animals discover
philosophy.

BLACKOUT.

2 EXT. JUNGLE - LATER

2

A comic montage.

PARROT hangs signs.

PARROT

"PRIVATE TECHNIQUE."

Another.

PARROT (CONT'D)

"NO OBSERVATION WITHOUT PERMISSION."

Another.

PARROT (CONT'D)

"LOOKING AT THIS NEST CONSTITUTES
ACCEPTANCE OF TERMS."

NINO

Higher.

PARROT

Nobody can read it higher.

NINO

Exactly.

At the ant colony, AGRA guards an entrance.

A YOUNG ANT approaches.

YOUNG ANT

Queen Agra, the neighboring colony
(MORE)

YOUNG ANT (CONT'D)

lost
their garden in a flood. They asked
for
a little starter fungus.

AGRA

No.

YOUNG ANT

They're hungry.

AGRA

If we share cultures, everyone will
farm
our strain.

MARA

Your strain?

AGRA

Please don't start.

MARA

I haven't started. I've been growing
for
millions of years.

Across the stage, SPINNER catches PIP staring.

SPINNER

Are you measuring my radial threads?

PIP

I'm sitting here.

SPINNER

Suspiciously.

PIP

I am a frog.

SPINNER

Exactly what an industrial spy would
say.

At the stream, SKYSHOT addresses three young fish.

SKYSHOT

Rule one of aerial hunting--

He notices PROFESSOR FINN.

SKYSHOT (CONT'D)

Private lesson.

PROFESSOR FINN

I wasn't listening.

SKYSHOT

Your ear is facing me.

PROFESSOR FINN

Fish don't have external ears.

SKYSHOT

See? Always stealing knowledge.

DAME DAMSEL puts a toll gate across a tiny side channel.

RIVER

What is that?

DAME DAMSEL

Infrastructure access fee.

RIVER

I'm water.

DAME DAMSEL

And now you're premium water.

The ensemble laughs.

Then the laughter thins.

A group of birds tries to repair a storm-damaged nest.

NINO sees them struggling.

YOUNG BIRD

Nino, how do you anchor the first loop?

NINO

Trade secret.

YOUNG BIRD

One loop.

NINO

That's how it begins.

He flies away.

SPINNER watches.

SPINNER

You could've shown them.

NINO

You could publish your web pattern.

SPINNER

That's different.

NINO

Naturally.

They separate.

BAOBAB rustles.

BAOBAB

Funny.

PARROT

What's funny?

BAOBAB

Everyone wants recognition for being original.

PARROT

And?

BAOBAB

Nobody remembers who invented shade.

3 EXT. GREAT CLEARING - AFTERNOON

3

JUDGE HORNBILL has ordered demonstrations.

JUDGE HORNBILL

If we're going to protect knowledge,
we
should understand what we're
protecting.

NINO steps forward.

NINO

At last, culture.

He loops grass around a flexible branch.

NINO (CONT'D)

A good nest isn't just a pile.

You choose fibers that bend without
snapping. You anchor. Loop. Pull.
Interlock.

PIP

You just taught us.

NINO freezes.

NINO

Forget that.

PIP

Already practicing.

NINO

Frog!

PIP

Bird!

SPINNER takes center.

She releases silk.

SPINNER

A web responds to wind, prey,
available
supports, damage, humidity--

NINO

And fashion?

SPINNER

No.

NINO

Sad.

SPINNER

Some threads frame the structure.
Others
capture prey. I rebuild when
conditions
change.

JUDGE HORNBILL

So the design isn't fixed?

SPINNER

Of course not. The environment edits
it.

MARA

Interesting phrase.

SPINNER

Don't.

BURR demonstrates a tunnel with sticks.

BURR

If soil is loose, you brace. If it's
wet,
you change direction. If roots are
here,
you work around them.

BAOBAB

Thank you.

BURR

Mostly.

TIK

Termite mounds also exploit airflow
and
thermal gradients.

BURR

Show-off.

TIK

You eat roots.

BURR

We all have hobbies.

DAME DAMSEL builds a miniature dam.

DAME DAMSEL

Water pushes. Wood resists. Mud
seals.
But the important part is reading
the
current.

RIVER

Finally somebody asks what I'm
doing.

DAME DAMSEL

I didn't say ask.

RIVER

Close enough.

SKYSHOT circles below an overhanging branch.

A toy insect is perched above.

SKYSHOT

Watch.

He bursts upward and knocks it down.

CHEERS.

SKYSHOT lands with maximum dignity.

SKYSHOT (CONT'D)

Natural talent.

PROFESSOR FINN

And water refraction, body
mechanics,
practice, prey behavior--

SKYSHOT

Natural. Talent.

PROFESSOR FINN

Fine.

AGRA's workers bring leaves toward a model fungus garden.

AGRA

We don't eat most of these leaves
directly. We process plant material
and
cultivate our food.

MARA

And the fungus breaks down material
the
ants can't efficiently use alone.

AGRA

Yes.

MARA

So your famous secret is already a
partnership.

Silence.

AGRA

Objection.

JUDGE HORNBILL

To biology?

AGRA

To her tone.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Overruled.

MARA

You tend fungus. Fungus feeds ants.
Plants feed fungus. Soil supports
plants.
Microbes recycle what dies.

She looks around.

MARA (CONT'D)

Where exactly would you draw the
fence?

AGRA

Around my colony.

MARA

Roots cross it.

AGRA

Then underground.

MARA

My threads cross that.

AGRA

You're difficult.

MARA

I'm a fungus. Boundaries are suggestions.

The ensemble laughs.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Court adjourned until tomorrow.

He raises the seedpod.

JUDGE HORNBILL (CONT'D)

Nobody invent anything overnight.

PARROT

What if inspiration strikes?

JUDGE HORNBILL

Write it on a leaf.

PARROT

And register it?

JUDGE HORNBILL

Go home.

BLACKOUT.

4 EXT. JUNGLE - NIGHT

4

Thunder.

Rain begins gently, then becomes violent.

RIVER

Coming through.

DAME DAMSEL

That's a lot of water.

RIVER

Premium water.

DAME DAMSEL

Not now.

She races toward her dam.

BURR emerges, soaked.

BURR

My eastern tunnel's flooding!

DAME DAMSEL

Dig an overflow channel.

BURR

Where?

DAME DAMSEL

Down-gradient.

BURR

Which way is down-gradient underground?

TIK

I can help.

BURR

Your ventilation design is proprietary.

TIK

You mocked it.

BURR

I was younger then.

TIK

That was this morning.

A tree limb crashes.

NINO's nest swings wildly.

YOUNG BIRD

The anchor!

NINO

Double-loop it!

YOUNG BIRD

How?

NINO hesitates.

Another gust.

NINO

Like this!

He demonstrates rapidly.

NINO (CONT'D)

Under, around, back through! Pull!

The young bird copies him.

The nest holds.

NINO stares at it.

YOUNG BIRD

Thanks.

NINO

Yeah.

Don't tell anyone.

YOUNG BIRD

Everyone just saw.

NINO looks at the audience.

NINO

Terrific.

Elsewhere, AGRA's colony floods.

YOUNG ANT

The fungus chamber!

AGRA

Move the brood!

MARA

Higher ground. There's a dry root
cavity
beneath Baobab.

AGRA

How do you know?

MARA

I'm connected to it.

AGRA

Can we use it?

MARA

Of course.

AGRA

No license?

MARA

Agra, you're drowning.

AGRA

Right.

They rush.

At the stream, a small pool is cut off by debris.

PROFESSOR FINN

Fry trapped!

SKYSHOT

I'll clear it.

PROFESSOR FINN

You can't jump through a log.

SKYSHOT

Watch me.

He tries.

THUD.

SKYSHOT (CONT'D)

I have revised my position.

DAME DAMSEL

I can redirect the side flow.

BURR

I can tunnel under the debris.

TIK

I can tell you where the bank will hold.

SPINNER

I can mark the safest line between roots.

PROFESSOR FINN

Do it.

Everyone works.

The water shifts.

The trapped fish escape.

A pause.

They stare at one another.

BURR

Did we just collaborate?

DAME DAMSEL

Temporary emergency exception.

SPINNER

Obviously.

MARA

Obviously.

LIGHTS FADE.

5 **EXT. GREAT CLEARING - MORNING**

5

Broken branches. Mud. Torn leaves.

The jungle looks bruised.

PARROT

Damage report.

(reading)

Three nests lost. Two tunnels collapsed.
One dam partially breached. Ant fungus
garden damaged. Several webs gone.

SPINNER

All my webs are gone.

PARROT

Right. Several sounds kinder.

SPINNER

Don't make my tragedy editorial.

NINO examines a ruined nest.

NINO

I spent eleven days on that.

SPINNER

I spent a night on mine.

NINO

Exactly.

SPINNER

That wasn't agreement.

AGRA enters.

AGRA

We lost half the garden.

MARA

The surviving culture can regrow.

AGRA

Slowly.

A YOUNG ANT whispers to her.

YOUNG ANT

The neighboring colony offered us
some
of theirs.

AGRA

The colony we refused?

YOUNG ANT

Yes.

AGRA

Why?

YOUNG ANT

They said fungus doesn't care about
pride.

MARA

Smart fungus.

AGRA

You are enjoying this.

MARA

A little.

JUDGE HORNBILL enters.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Court resumes.

NINO

Seriously?

JUDGE HORNBILL

Especially seriously.

They gather.

JUDGE HORNBILL (CONT'D)

Last night, how many of you used
knowledge
belonging to another species?

No one raises anything.

JUDGE HORNBILL (CONT'D)

Fine.

How many would have lost offspring,
homes, food, or neighbors without it?

Slowly, almost everyone raises a limb,
wing, fin, antenna, or leaf.

JUDGE HORNBILL (CONT'D)

Interesting.

SKYSHOT

Emergency conditions.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Does water know it's an emergency?

RIVER

I barely know it's Tuesday.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Does a falling branch pause to check
licensing terms?

BAOBAB

Never has.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Then perhaps the problem isn't
whether
knowledge has value.

Perhaps the problem is believing value
only exists when knowledge is withheld.

AGRA

That's too simple.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Good.

Then complicate it.

6 EXT. CLEARING - CONTINUOUS

6

AGRA steps forward.

AGRA

Sharing isn't automatically noble.

My workers spend their lives maintaining
our garden.

If another colony takes everything we've
learned and gives nothing back, that's
not cooperation.

NINO

Exactly.

I practice. I fail. I rebuild.

If someone copies the result and calls themselves the genius, I'm allowed to be annoyed.

SPINNER

Very annoyed.

PROFESSOR FINN

Recognition matters.

DAME DAMSEL

So does responsibility.

If I teach someone to alter a stream and they flood three burrows, "knowledge should be free" won't dry anybody's bed.

BURR

Thank you.

MARA

Good.

Everyone turns.

MARA (CONT'D)

Now we're finally talking about the real thing.

Not ownership.

Relationships.

TIK

Explain.

MARA

A forest isn't generous because nobody has boundaries.

It survives because boundaries are porous enough for exchange.

Roots take water.

Leaves give sugars.

Fungi trade minerals.

Pollinators move pollen.

Predators move energy.

Decomposers return bodies to soil.

Nothing gives everything.

Nothing keeps everything.

PIP

So what's the rule?

MARA

There isn't one.

PARROT

Terrible slogan.

MARA

Life isn't a slogan.

PARROT

Worse.

NINO

Then what are we supposed to do?

BAOBAB speaks.

BAOBAB

Pay attention.

Everyone quiets.

BAOBAB (CONT'D)

A forest is an argument that has
lasted
long enough to become music.

PARROT

That's annoyingly good.

BAOBAB

Thank you.

BAOBAB's branches move.

BAOBAB (CONT'D)

You want credit? Give credit.

You want respect? Ask permission when
permission matters.

You want survival?

Share what must be shared.

And when you borrow from the living world,
remember that you are borrowing from
relatives.

AGRA

Relatives?

BAOBAB

Very distant relatives.

BURR

How distant?

BAOBAB

Please don't make me explain
evolution
before lunch.

7 **EXT. RIVERBANK - DAYS LATER**

7

Heat.

The stream is shrinking.

RIVER

I'm low.

DAME DAMSEL

I can see that.

RIVER

Just checking.

DAME DAMSEL studies the bank.

DAME DAMSEL

If I reinforce here, I can hold a
deeper
pool.

PROFESSOR FINN

That could keep fish alive.

PIP

And frogs.

SKYSHOT

And my lunch.

PIP

Less inspiring.

DAME DAMSEL

But slowing water here could reduce
flow
downstream.

BURR

My burrow is downstream.

AGRA

So is one of our foraging routes.

NINO

And my favorite bathing branch.

SPINNER

Tragic.

NINO

Thank you.

SPINNER

Still not agreement.

DAME DAMSEL

We need information.

BURR

My tunnels show where the soil stays damp.

TIK

Our mound temperatures indicate where air and moisture move.

BAOBAB

My roots know where the deeper water is.

MARA

And I connect roots across much of this bank.

PROFESSOR FINN

Fish can tell you which pools remain oxygenated.

SKYSHOT

I can tell you where insects gather.

PIP

I can tell you where mosquitoes gather.

SKYSHOT

Same department.

DAME DAMSEL

All right.

Everyone talks.

DAME DAMSEL draws a map in mud.

SPINNER lays silk lines across it.

BURR adds tunnels.

TIK marks stable ground.

FINN marks pools.

MARA marks roots.

NINO drops colored fibers at nesting sites.

AGRA places leaf fragments along ant routes.

They step back.

The map is beautiful.

PARROT

What do we call it?

DAME DAMSEL

A watershed plan.

PARROT

Too boring.

NINO

The Grand Cooperative Ecological Design.

SPINNER

Too Nino.

BURR

Mud map.

Everyone considers.

DAME DAMSEL

Mud map.

They begin construction.

A rhythmic work sequence develops.

ANTS carry.

BEAVERS place branches.

RODENTS dig.

TERMITES pack earth.

BIRDS carry fibers.

SPIDERS mark lines.

FISH splash at weak points.

FROGS call warnings.

Plants bend.

The stage becomes a machine made of living bodies.

RIVER

Easy.

Easy.

There.

Water enters a newly shaped pool, then continues downstream.

CHEERS.

DAME DAMSEL

Nobody owns that.

BURR

We all built it.

NINO

I did make the flags.

SPINNER

Of course you did.

8 EXT. CLEARING - EVENING

8

PARROT has set up a desk.

A sign reads:

JUNGLE INTELLECTUAL PROPERTY
OFFICE
FAST APPROVAL
NO REFUNDS

PARROT

Next!

SKYSHOT approaches.

SKYSHOT

I'd like to patent jumping.

PARROT

Denied.

Why? SKYSHOT

Frogs. PARROT

PIP waves.

Fine. Jumping from water. SKYSHOT

Fish. PARROT

Jumping from water at insects. SKYSHOT

Still crowded. PARROT

Can I trademark "SkyShot"? SKYSHOT

Absolutely. PARROT

Really? SKYSHOT

I have no idea. PARROT

NINO arrives.

I want protection for my signature knot. NINO

Describe it. PARROT

Nice try. NINO

This office is fake. SPINNER

"Experimental." PARROT

AGRA arrives carrying a mushroom.

We want to register a shared cultivation agreement. AGRA

PARROT

Shared?

AGRA

Our colony will exchange fungus cultures with neighboring colonies after floods, disease, or crop failure.

MARA

And nobody calls fungus property.

AGRA

We're negotiating that sentence.

MARA

We're not.

AGRA

See? Partnership.

NINO looks thoughtful.

NINO

Could I teach weaving and still ask students to credit who taught them?

JUDGE HORNBILL, entering:

JUDGE HORNBILL

Sounds reasonable.

NINO

Could I refuse to reveal where I hide my best nesting fibers?

JUDGE HORNBILL

Also reasonable.

NINO

So sharing doesn't mean surrendering everything?

JUDGE HORNBILL

Who told you it did?

Everyone looks at everyone else.

PARROT

We may have built this entire conflict on a bad definition.

SPINNER

That would be extremely on-brand for us.

BLACKOUT.

9 EXT. CLEARING - MORNING

9

A hand-painted sign:

THE SCHOOL OF THINGS WE KNOW
AND THINGS WE'RE STILL FIGURING OUT

NINO teaches young birds.

NINO

Loop under.

Not over.

Unless the branch bends this way.

Then over.

YOUNG BIRD

Yesterday you said under.

NINO

Yesterday's branch was different.

YOUNG BIRD

So there's no perfect recipe?

NINO

Welcome to nature.

Nearby, SPINNER demonstrates silk.

SPINNER

Copying the shape isn't enough.

You need to respond to the place.

PIP

So the environment is part of the design.

SPINNER

Exactly.

PIP

Can I quote you?

SPINNER

Credit me.

PIP

Deal.

At another station, BURR and TIK compare structures.

BURR

I dig escape routes.

TIK

We build networks.

BURR

I reinforce loose soil.

TIK

We regulate internal conditions.

BURR

Your tunnels are still tiny.

TIK

Your ventilation remains primitive.

They shake paw and antenna.

BURR

Friends?

TIK

Absolutely not.

BURR

Good.

At the water, PROFESSOR FINN speaks to young animals.

PROFESSOR FINN

Different cichlid species solve
family
life differently.

Some guard territories. Some guard
offspring. Some carry eggs or young in
their mouths.

SKYSHOT

And some fish leap for bugs.

PROFESSOR FINN

This is my class.

SKYSHOT

Cross-disciplinary learning.

FINN sighs.

SKYSHOT

Want the aerial hunting demonstration?

The students cheer.

SKYSHOT

Finally, academia respects me.

He leaps.

SPLASH.

10 EXT. GREAT CLEARING - SUNSET

10

JUDGE HORNBILL convenes the final court.

JUDGE HORNBILL

We began with a question.

Who owns knowledge?

PARROT

I have several answers and a newsletter.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Nobody subscribed.

PARROT

Yet.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Agra?

AGRA

Knowledge can belong to a tradition.

But traditions survive by being practiced, adapted, and sometimes shared.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Nino?

NINO

Skill deserves credit.

Also, apparently, students.

YOUNG BIRD

We're exhausting.

NINO

Deeply.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Spinner?

SPINNER

No design exists outside its environment.

Change the branch, wind, humidity, prey, and the web changes.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Dame Damsel?

DAME DAMSEL

Engineering changes other lives.

So building gives you responsibility, not just bragging rights.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Burr?

BURR

Never dig alone in wet soil.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Philosophically.

BURR

That was philosophical.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Finn?

PROFESSOR FINN

Life is full of solutions.

No species has all of them.

JUDGE HORNBILL

SkyShot?

SKYSHOT

I'm still extremely impressive.

PROFESSOR FINN

We know.

SKYSHOT

And...

(beat)

I hunt because insects live above water, because plants support insects, because water supports me.

The trick isn't mine alone.

PROFESSOR FINN

There he is.

SKYSHOT

Don't make it weird.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Mara?

MARA

I have nothing to add.

PARROT

Impossible.

MARA

Look down.

The stage darkens.

Beneath the characters, glowing threads
appear.

Roots.

Fungal networks.

Burrows.

Water channels.

Ant tunnels.

Above them, silk threads catch light.

Bird nests hang between branches.

The ensemble slowly fills the stage.

MARA (CONT'D)

You keep imagining yourselves as
separate
inventions.

But life keeps connecting the diagrams.

The ensemble forms a loose circle.

BAOBAB

A leaf falls.

An ENSEMBLE LEAF falls.

MARA

Fungi and microbes break it down.

AGRA

Nutrients return to soil.

BAOBAB

Roots take them.

NINO

Branches grow.

SPINNER

Branches hold webs.

PIP

Webs catch insects.

SKYSHOT

Some insects escape.

PIP

Important detail.

SKYSHOT

They become lunch somewhere else.

PROFESSOR FINN

Fish move nutrients through water.

RIVER

Water moves through land.

DAME DAMSEL

Dams reshape water.

BURR

Burrows reshape soil.

TIK

Soil holds worlds.

MARA

And death feeds life again.

Silence.

JUDGE HORNBILL

So where does one invention end?

No answer.

JUDGE HORNBILL (CONT'D)

Where does one creature end?

MARA

At the skin, perhaps.

BAOBAB

But not at the consequence.

PARROT

I'm writing that down.

JUDGE HORNBILL walks to center.

JUDGE HORNBILL

This court therefore rejects the idea that the jungle is a warehouse of separate geniuses guarding separate treasures.

NINO

Strong wording.

JUDGE HORNBILL

It recognizes craft.

It recognizes effort.

It recognizes traditions, boundaries, credit, care, and responsibility.

But above all--

He looks around.

JUDGE HORNBILL (CONT'D)

It recognizes dependence.

AGRA takes a small piece of fungus culture to a neighboring ant.

NINO hands grass fiber to a young bird.

SPINNER stretches a thread between two branches.

BURR opens a tunnel.

DAME DAMSEL releases water through the dam.

SKYSHOT leaps.

PIP jumps out of his way.

PIP

Hey!

SKYSHOT

Sorry!

PIP

You absolutely were not!

Laughter.

Music emerges from the ecosystem itself.

Water.

Wingbeats.

Frog calls.

Wood tapping.

Leaves.

The rhythm grows.

PARROT

We wanted to know who owned the
jungle's
ideas.

AGRA

Turns out the jungle had another
question.

NINO

What good is an idea if the world
around
it collapses?

SPINNER

What good is a perfect web without
branches?

PROFESSOR FINN

A fish without water?

BURR

A tunnel without soil?

DAME DAMSEL

A dam without a river?

MARA

A fungus without partners?

BAOBAB

A tree without yesterday's dead
leaves?

The ensemble closes in.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Every creature changes its
environment.

Every environment changes its creatures.

No nest is merely a nest.

No burrow merely a hole.

No dam merely timber.

No web merely silk.

No fungus garden merely food.

They are relationships made visible.

The jungle brightens.

JUDGE HORNBILL (CONT'D)

That is why this place breathes.

Not because everyone is the same.

Not because nobody competes.

Not because every secret must disappear.

It breathes because difference does not
cancel dependence.

The creatures listen.

JUDGE HORNBILL (CONT'D)

Each life brings something.

Each life takes something.

Each life leaves something behind.

Together, they make a living bouquet.

PARROT

Bouquets don't breathe.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Parrot.

PARROT

Sorry.

JUDGE HORNBILL

A living, breathing bouquet.

PARROT

Much better.

JUDGE HORNBILL

And its strongest thread is not
ownership.

SPINNER

Careful.

JUDGE HORNBILL

Not even silk.

SPINNER

Acceptable.

JUDGE HORNBILL

It is interdependence.

A long beat.

RIVER

Ready?

DAME DAMSEL

Ready.

RIVER

Then open it.

DAME DAMSEL removes a branch.

Water flows.

Lights ripple through the ensemble.

The creatures return to their activities,
but now those activities overlap.

Ants carry leaves beneath a bird's nest.

A spider anchors silk to a branch.

A frog shelters beneath a leaf.

Fish move through the water.

A beaver repairs the bank.

A rodent digs around roots rather than
through them.

Mushrooms emerge beside the tree.

The jungle becomes a single moving image.

BAOBAB

Nobody lives alone.

MARA

Nobody creates alone.

AGRA

Nobody survives alone.

NINO

But I still want credit for that knot.

SPINNER

Fine.

NINO

Thank you.

PARROT

Breaking news!

Everyone groans.

PARROT (CONT'D)

Jungle survives argument!

JUDGE HORNBILL

That's your headline?

PARROT

Wait.

He thinks.

PARROT (CONT'D)

"Jungle Discovers Everyone Needs Everyone."

BURR

Bit sentimental.

TIK

Accurate, though.

PARROT

I'll take it.

The ensemble faces the audience.

ALL

Nothing lives alone.

BLACKOUT.

A moment of darkness.

Then the sound of one small insect.

Another answers.

Then a frog.

A bird.

Water.

Wind through leaves.

The sounds overlap until the jungle is
audible again.

FADE OUT.

THE END